

Hepatic artery embolisation for neuroendocrine tumours (NETs)

A hepatic artery embolisation can sometimes shrink NETs in the liver. It can also relieve the symptoms of carcinoid syndrome.

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What is hepatic artery embolisation?

Hepatic artery embolisation is used to treat tumours in the [liver](#). Tumours need a blood supply to survive. This treatment works by reducing the blood flow to the liver.

Hepatic artery embolisation for NETs

A hepatic artery embolisation can sometimes shrink a [neuroendocrine tumour \(NET\)](#) in the liver. It can also help to relieve the symptoms of [carcinoid syndrome](#). You may be offered this treatment for the following reasons:

- You have NETs in your liver, and surgery is not an option. This may be because of where the NETs are, or you do not want surgery, or you are not fit enough for an operation
- Other treatments for the NET have not helped.
- The NET is producing a lot of hormones that are causing symptoms.

Having hepatic artery embolisation

At the hospital before you have the treatment, you may be given a drip (infusion) of [octreotide](#). This helps reduce or prevent [carcinoid symptoms](#).

Treatment is usually done in the x-ray department (radiology) of the hospital by a specialist doctor known as an interventional radiologist. You may be given a sedative to make you feel sleepy. During the hepatic artery embolisation the doctor gently puts a thin tube into the main blood vessel in your

groin (the femoral artery). You will have a local anaesthetic to numb the skin in that area.

Guided by a scan, they slowly feed the tube into the main blood vessel of the [liver](#) (the hepatic artery). They then inject a drug that blocks the blood supply.

Sometimes the drug is combined with [chemotherapy](#). This is called [chemoembolisation](#). The highly concentrated chemotherapy stays in the tumour to kill some of the cells and shrink the tumour.

Chemoembolisation is sometimes called TACE (trans-arterial chemoembolisation) or CT-ACE (computerised tomography guided arterial chemoembolisation).

After treatment

You will rest in bed for a few hours afterwards. You may stay in hospital overnight. You may feel sick, have tummy (abdominal) pain and a high temperature for a few days afterwards. Your doctor or nurse can give you more information.

About our information

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our neuroendocrine tumours (NETs) information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at cancerinformationteam@macmillan.org.uk

Esmo clinical practice guidelines: endocrine and neuroendocrine cancers. Available from: www.esmo.org/guidelines/endocrine-and-neuroendocrine-cancers (accessed May 2021).

Reviewers

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer. It has been approved by Senior Medical Editor, Dr Paul Ross, Consultant Medical Oncologist.

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

How we can help

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email us

Email the Macmillan Fundraising team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

[Get help](#)

